Predicting Complaint Eligibility for Accountability Mechanisms

Accountability Counsel is a nonprofit that helps communities challenge development projects such as dams or mines that threaten their land, livelihoods, and rights. When international institutions finance those projects, affected communities can file complaints with accountability mechanisms that review whether environmental and social standards were violated. Each complaint must pass this review, and many promising filings fail on technicalities. In partnership with the University of Chicago Data Science Clinic, this project developed a tool that reads draft complaints and identifies improvements.

The team asked a language model to classify complaints as eligible or ineligible with a transparent scoring framework built directly from the official eligibility criteria of a given mechanism. The tool evaluates each complaint across thirteen factors, including whether the filing identifies the project, describes concrete harm, links that harm to project activities, identifies the affected community, and states a desired outcome. In analyzing historical complaints, several factors predicted eligibility more strongly than others.

The final system produces a per-factor scorecard that highlights which eligibility criteria a draft satisfies and where additional detail or evidence may be needed. By emphasizing transparency and actionable feedback rather than binary prediction alone, the approach can also generalize to other international accountability mechanisms.

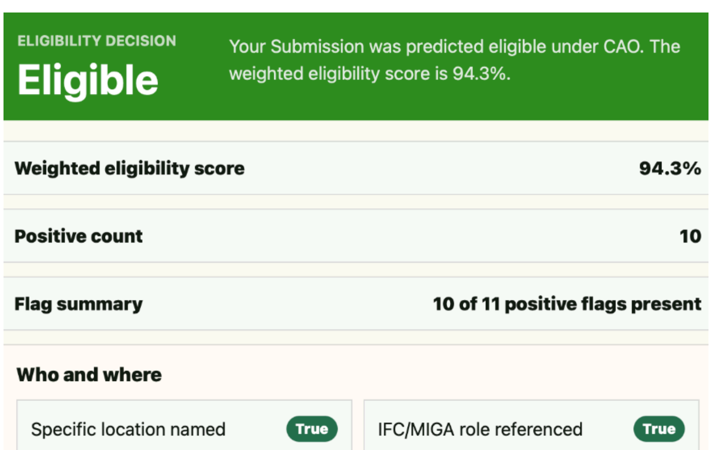

Figure 1. A mockup of the complaint eligibility reviewer UI that takes an LLM prompt and synthesizes results into an interface that complainants can use. The review interface also marks when specific elements of a good complaint from the guidelines are met.

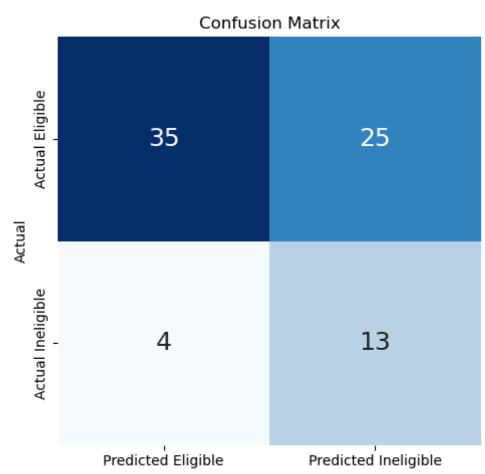

Figure 2. LLM-based eligibility predictions. The model accurately predicts documents and penalizes eligible cases, suggesting that the LLM identifies ineligible cases well.